

Rav Yechiel Spiro quotes the Rebbe of Sanz that one of a number of reasons that we place our hands over our eyes when we say קריאת שמע is because we are showing that השם אלוֹקֵינוּ Hashem of רחמים אחד; השם אחד - השם אחד; רחמים and דין is one. When our eyes are open, there are times when it does not appear that way. But if we close our eyes, we realize that not everything is what it seems. We can only see a limited vision. Our ability to see is made specifically limited so we should understand our limitations and realize Hashem is the one who is all powerful. We, no matter if we think we're doing great, are very limited in what we're able to accomplish.

A few months after the end of World War II, the אמרי אמת, the Gerrer Rebbe, had a guest, a Holocaust survivor. He was completely alone and completely צעבראכן. He had come to the אמרי אמת for words of חיזוק. He invited the man to stay for Shabbos. During the Shabbos meal, the אמרי אמת shared with this man the following incredible thought. “When משה רבינו recounts the breaking of the לוחות (דברים ט"ז:י"ז), he tells them לְעֵינֵיכֶם - I have smashed them before your eyes. What does that extra word לְעֵינֵיכֶם add? Just say וְאַשְׁבַּרְם - I broke the לוחות. They all saw it. What is the word לְעֵינֵיכֶם teaching us?” The man perked up when he heard this קשיא.

The אמרי אמת continued “When יוסף put שמעון in jail, he also did לְעֵינֵיכֶם (בראשית מ"ב:כ"ד), in front of their very eyes. But what does Rashi tell you? As soon as they left, he took him out of jail and gave him to eat and drink. He treated him nicely. But to their eyes, שמעון was put in jail.” The Rebbe looked at this יד צעבראכענע, and he put his hand on him. “R' Yid, just as by יוסף it was לְעֵינֵיכֶם, just like the שבירת לוחות were לְעֵינֵיכֶם and only appears that way. The broken לוחות only looked to us to be broken, but they're really not.”

The man began to cry. He understood precisely what the Rebbe meant to tell him. It may have appeared that his life and his family were completely broken, but that's only to our limited vision in עולם הזה. It is only in this world that the burning סנה from משה רבינו was burning. It wasn't burning. Only to our eyes did it appear to be burning. He knew that there will come a day that the bush will not be burning.

R' Moshe Sherer once said that what one can see with his eyes open is limited. But if one closes his eyes, his vision is unlimited, and he can see forever. On השעה באב we cry because we have to. We've lost so much. For the צדיקים who died, for the people of our generation. The only reason that we cry is because our eyes are open. If we cover our eyes and say אחד השם אלוֹקֵינוּ ה', we realize that everything that הקדוש ברוך הוא does for us is good. Through our tears, we have to have the אמונה that we will once again be able to see the בית המקדש, בנין בית המקדש, we'll be able to see the עבודה, be able to see all that Hashem does is really for the good.

